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Automatische Programmerzeugung für einen Blechhandhabungsroboter vor einer Abkantpresse

Automatic Program Generation for a Sheet-Metal Handling Robot in Front of a Press Brake

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Abstract

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List of Abbreviations

OLP : Offline Programming
ROS : Robot Operating System
TCP : Tool Center Point
UI : User Interface
CAD : Computer-Aided Design
CAM : Computer-Aided Manufacturing
API : Application Programming Interface
DOF : Degree of Freedom
FR : Functional Requirements
NFR : Non-Functional Requirements

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1 Introduction

2 State of the Art

2.1 Manual And teach pendant based robot programming.

The programming of the industrial robots follows a programming approach based on teach pendant programming, which means, the robot movement and motions are explicitly defined and programmed directly during the operations. The programmer subsequently uses this approach to position and then programs the robot to move to a series of specific target positions. The robot subsequently saves these positions using programming languages specific to each robot type and brand. Despite advances in programming approaches for robotics systems, this method is still commonly used to its owing to its reliability and its usefulness in interacting with real world systems [1] . However, this may require expert knowledge of the robot's kinematics, tooling, and process constraints. Minor changes in geometry, fixture placement or cell layout often involve extensive manual reprogramming, increases commissioning effort and system downtime. Therefore, teach pendant programming scales poorly in flexible manufacturing systems characterized by frequent changeovers coupled with small batch sizes. In terms of the sheet metal handling and the automation of the press brake operations, the restrictions can appear even more considerable. When working with these pieces of sheet metal that can be flexible and large in size, their handling involves further challenges that need to be addressed, revolving around reachability issues and collision avoidance. In terms of manual programming , each step of the planned process of the bending involves the precise determination by the user of the intermediary positions for each action of the manipulator necessary for the accomplishment of the task at hand .Such an approach can appear heavily dependent on the users expertise for the purpose of avoiding the iterative try and error approach that might be inevitably required during the plant operations [2] .Especially , more classical robot programming paradigms have be identified as insufficient in terms of abstraction and flexibility needs for current applications in industrial robotics, especially when high flexibility and fast reconfiguration are at stake [1] .Such an approach to programming the robot , through interaction with the teach pendant itself , tend to create program that are more dependent on the specific type of the robot used and also the cell configuration, programming style of each particular operator etc.

As a result, manual teach in pendant programming methods have traditionally been seen to be unsuitable for advanced automation tasks. that often requires increased flexibility, analyses of process knowledge, and minimization of human interventions. It is realization that sparked off interest in alternative offline programming, task level programming and even methods of automatically generating robot programs, as discussed in the sections [1]

2.2 Offline programming approaches for industrial robots

The disadvantages associated with manual programming of industrial robotic arms lead to an increase in the uptake of offline programming in industrial applications. This programming method led to running the digital working environment using digital models of robots, tools, grippers and other components used for the programming without interrupting the real production. [1]

This programming is based on Computer aided Model (CAM) also known as the geometric or CAD models, which represent the robots, workpiece and all other components. These models allow robot programs to be simulated before they implement in the real working environment. Despite being associated with the disadvantages, offline programming also has some limitations when used in industrial applications.[3]

In robot- assisted sheet Metal handling presses brake operation, offline programming is commonly used for robot programs such as sheet metal handling, bending process, pick and regrip operations for sheet in different bending stages. Using virtual simulation, engineers can evaluate, validate and verify , and can identify the if the robot's reachability, regripping positions and bending sequences while safely avoiding the unreachable path to machines and fixtures. [2]. Even though this program offers many benefits, it relies heavily on exact digital models of robot cells. If the digital model does not perfectly match the real model configurations, due to the calibration error, fixture errors or in change in tool geometry model, the robot may misbehave in kinematics. In such cases, manual re- configuration needed, engineers must re-program during the commissioning. Another limitation of this programming is that it is less suitable for the environment with frequent changeovers and high-end product variety [1] This occurs because the programs are usually created for specific tasks and robot paths for, specific part geometry and bending process. [3] In case multi side bending process, regripping and regrasping operation is required, often require the workpiece to be temporarily place in orientation table and then grasped again in a dif-

ferent configuration. This is necessary to avoid collision with and optimize the robot kinematics. In this programming, these approaches are checked by the programmer, which increases the engineering effort that leads to limiting flexibility and time consuming. [2].

In summary, this program provides clear advantages and over manual programming by reducing the on-site teaching time and enabling virtual validation robot waypoints. However, it depends heavily on exact digital model and manual definition of task sequences reduces the efficiencies in industrial applications. These limitations have motivated into high level research, task oriented automatic program generation strategies, which aim to reduce human involvement while increasing the adaptability of the system. These approaches are explained in the following sections.

2.3 Automatic and Rule-Based Robot Program Generation

To reduce further engineering effort associated with manual and offline programming such as manual programming and offline programming, research in industrial robot section has increasingly focused on automatic program generation. This in-depth research aims to derive executable high level automated tasks with respect to robotics position and geometric information, thereby minimizing direct human re programming. In contrast to traditional offline programming, where engineer defines the motion trajectories, automated programming seeks to capture the environmental details in reusable and systematic representations.[1, 3].

A prominent solution executed in this method is rule based and task level robot program generation. In such methods, predefined rules or tasks are used to resolve the high-level constraints related to kinematics, tool orientation, and process feasibility. This rule-based programming reduces the operator role and enable the robot to perform intelligently for recurring task in industrial environment [3, 4]. Several researchers have been used reusable primitives as a foundation for automatic robot programming. Rather than programming individual motions, these complex robot behaviors represent a meaningful action such as grasping, repicking, or approaching target positions. [4, 5]. Automated programs is supported by geometric and feature based representation of parts such CAD Models or simplified geometric descriptions used for detecting or identifying the features such as grasping edges for the mechanical operations, approach directions, task sequences can be processed automatically. As compared to manual and conventional programming methods, this method enables adaptations to complex prod-

uct variants. [6]. This automated program generation has also been invented for sheet metal handling and robotic press brake automation applications, where repetitive task for bending operations and geometry is usually structured. In such systems, bending sequences, grasp configurations and placement strategies are derived from the constraints and geometric models rather than manual teaching. This reduces the engineer's effort and gives highly efficient output for repeatable similar workpieces. [2, 7].

Despite these advantages, rule-based robot program generations lead to some limitations. Most systems relay simply on the assumptions regarding part geometry, fixture layouts, tooling position and trajectories generations, which lead to restriction on applicability in highly variant part processes and low volume production scenarios. As task complexity increases, the number of rules may also get increased, which makes it hard to maintain the system, difficult to scale and lead to inconsistencies. [1, 4]. Regripping operations is one of the most highlighting problems in the sheet metal handling process. For multi-step bending , robot need to place the workpiece on temporary place called orientation table , which is used for the repegging and repositioning the workpiece for next sequence bending .Although there exist some regripping strategies , these are particularly for some specific tools and specific robot cells. [2, 7]. As a result, they do not support other setups well and limit the chances of automation.

Automatic program generation has also been combined with optimization-based methods, where trajectory quality is considered during motion generation. Such methods improve the execution performance with generating trajectory plans in robot handling tasks [8].

In conclusion, automatic and rule-based programs subsequently reduce the engineer's effort and increase consistency for complex task specifications. However, some approaches are still considered as the limitations, limited adaptability to process different variations about geometry and handling. These limitations give motivation to develop specific solutions with high degree automation, specifically for the sheet metal bending, which is the focus of this research.

2.4 Robotic Sheet-Metal Bending and Press-Brake Cells

Robotic press brake sheet metal bending has gained attention in industry due to the increasing demand for high productivity and consistent bending quality. In such systems, industrial robots are capable to handle sheet metal workpieces throughout the bending process, including gripping, positioning

at the press brake for bending process, reorientation for subsequent bending sequences and unloading process after the process completion. Compared to manual bending, robotic system reduces the operator's effort while ensures precise bending quality in a repeatable and reliable way. [1] Early research focused on analyzing feasibility of integrating industrial robots with traditional press brakes systems. These studies demonstrate that the sheet metal bending can be effectively performed when robot waypoints are carefully coordinated with the bending operation sequences. These results highlighted the importance of reliable synchronization between the robot and the press brake, particularly for precise process execution and accurate motion planning. [2]

Later studies of robotic sheet metal bending processes by researchers addressed the problem of process plaining, including the determination of bending sequences, selection of which tools need to be used for the specific bend and handling strategies for the workpiece. As a result, they showed bending depends on the geometry, reachability to process the bends. So, they found out that, make planning to make aware of unstable grasps or robot motions that cannot be executed during the process. [7] Unlike the rigid workpiece, the sheet metal continuously changes the shapes after each bending operation. This requires the robot to adjust the gripping position and adopt different orientational pickup through the process. To ensure safety, many robotic systems rely on conservative motion planning and fixed handling strategies. While this approach reduces the system complexity when dealing with the complex or varying part geometry. [2, 1] On the next stage, regripping becomes one of the most challenging parts for robotic bending. Often the sheet must be temporarily placed at an intermediate location and then repick again for the next bend, requiring appropriate regripping positions that are compatible with the bending tools. most existing systems rely on predefined regripping locations and manually planned regripping strategies. This significantly increases engineering effort and make system adaptability difficult for frequent process changes . [2, 7].

Research on path planning for robot assisted sheet metal bending shows constraints on their trajectories around press brake and tooling represents a major challenge. The waypoints must be carefully review in between the workspace especially during the reorientation and regripping operations [9].

Additional studies highlighted the role of grasp feasibility and stability, especially when vacuum based gripper are used. Research on vacuum gripper modelling and automatic grasp positions strongly depend on robustness and efficiency. [10]. However, these approaches tailored to specific de-

signed gripper types or handling strategies, and they are integrated into an automatic program generations press brake industrial applications

In industrial practice, robotic press brake bending performs well when the part geometry, tooling and process parameters are predefined. Such system typically relies on expensive offline preparation, accurate digital model simulations, manually defined handling and regripping strategies. However, as product variety increases, system flexibility significantly decreases. Consequently, the robotic press brake bending is well suited for structured and repetitive process. Nevertheless, current system still depends heavily on predefined process knowledge, pre planned trajectories and manually configured regripping strategies. These limitations reduce adaptability and have motivated extensive research into automated robot program generation methods that can respond to changing processes and production conditions. [1, 7].

2.5 Summary of the State of the Art and Identified Research Gap

The research has shown that the evolution of robot programming has evolved overtime. Early approaches use manuals teach pendant programming, followed by offline programming and recent development of automated and rule-based programming methods. Manual programming and offline programming are still widely used due to the robustness and direct physical interaction offered by programming. However, these methods require expert knowledge and therefore provide limited flexibility in industry. Offline programming optimizes some of these limitations of manual programming by enabling virtual simulation, but it remains limited by accuracy of digital model and need for manual defined task sequences. Automate rule-based program generation methods aims to reduce engineer efforts by enabling higher level system process which increases the consistency and modularity in robot programming. Nevertheless, these approaches rely on predefined rules and conservative planning assumptions, which restrict their applicability in highly variant production scenarios.

In the context of sheet metal bending and press brake automation, these limitations are prominently highlighted. The regripping, reposition workpiece for multiple bend on different sides significantly affects the reachability and grasp feasibility. Current robotic system therefore depends heavily on manually planned regripping strategies and pre-defined trajectory planning. As a result, adaptability to new part geometry remains limited, bending sequences lack flexibility and systematic reprogramming is still required when

process conditions change. Consequently, there exists a gap between existing robot programming approaches and the requirements of flexible robot sheet metal bending applications. There is a lack of methods that enable automatic program generations capable of addressing these constraints, reducing programming time, and allowing non experts operators to configure and execute bending processes. Addressing this gap is essential for increasing flexibility and adaptability in modern robotic industry

3 System Concept and Methodology

3.1 Problem Definition and Objectives

The state of the art has shown clearly that industrial robots are widely used for the press brake sheet metal bending, primarily through manual programming or predefined programming methods. These methods perform well in structured scenarios with fixed part position, geometries, and bending sequences. However, as product variants increase, the adoption of such robot programming approaches requires manual reprogramming and time consuming.

In press brake bending, after each bending operation, the shape of the sheet metal changes. Each geometric change affects robot reachability, gripping feasibility and grip point calculations, motion trajectories. Consequently, handling and regripping should be planned carefully. Previous research shows that managing this constraint is one of the most time-consuming and complex aspects of robotic bending processes particularly when handled manually.

From a methodological perspective, the limitations of this robot programming approaches related to their low-level nature. programmers must define the robot paths, position of tools and individual waypoints. This makes the programming, tightly coupled to a specific robot, grip positions or tool setups and making the reorientation or regripping strategies difficult to adapt. Robotic literature clearly indicates that such low-level programming does not scale well as system complexity increases and flexibility requirements grow [1]. This observation motivated research into the higher-level representation, where motion execution and decision making integrated with a unified framework. These methods aim to simplify handling constraints and promote reusable robot programs. While these strategies have been implemented in other robotic applications, they have not yet been implemented in robotic press brake sheet metal bending, particularly when the position and geometry changes must be explicitly considered.

Based on these observation , the central problem addressed in this thesis can be defined as follow: There is a lack of a systematic approach for automatic generation of robot programs for press brake sheet metal bending that explicitly accounts for changing workpiece positions and geometry , handling feasibility and regripping requirements while minimizing the man-

ual programming .

The primary objective of this thesis is to develop a conceptual and methodological framework for the automatic generation of the robot program that integrates bending, handling and regripping operations in one workflow. This proposed method aims to reduce manual programming effort and improve adaptability to different part geometries. To achieve this objective ,the work focuses on integrating bending sequences , handling actions , opposite side bending and regripping operation and which are validated and verified in simulation environment compatible with industrial robot environment .The scope of the thesis is limited to virtual environment and conceptual evaluation.

3.2 Requirement Definition and Management

To ensure a systematic and verifiable development of the proposed automatic robot program generation approach, the system design is guided by explicitly defined requirements. These requirements turn the research gap and problem formulation into engineering objectives that can later be verified and validated. The requirement that are explained in this chapter are directly derived from the limitations identified in the state of art and from the objectives formulated in 3.1. Rather than describing implementation details , the requirement specify what the system must achieve under which condition it must operate .This separation ensures that design decision remain traceable and that verification activities can be performed objectively. The requirement are classified into functional and non-functional requirements .Functional requirements describe the expected system behavior and capabilities , while nonfunctional requirements define the quality attributes such as usability , robustness and safety .In addition , system constraints and assumptions are explicitly stated to scope of the work and to define the operational boundaries of the proposed solution To support systematic verification, each requirement is formulated to Specific measurable Achievable Relevant Timebound (SMART) principle. Furthermore, each requirement is linked to system components and verifications steps. This traceability ensures that all requirements can be checked later and that the development process remains transparent and consistent.

3.2.1 Functional Requirements

Functional requirements specify the capabilities that the system provides in order to address the problem of automatic robot program generation for press brake sheet metal bending. These requirements define the expected system behavior from the task execution, operator interaction, trajectory generation and recovery mechanism. At a high level, the system shall enable the automatic generation of robot programs for multi-step sheet metal bending process without requiring manual t programming. The system shall support the execution of bending sequences that involve changes in workspace geometry, orientation, handling and regripping strategies.

A central functional aspects of the system is the consideration of work piece geometry evolution during bending process .Since the shape , position , orientation of the sheet metal changes after each bending operations , the system shall be feasible to handle the current geometric state and position of the workpiece when generating subsequent actions for the next task. This requirement is essential to ensure feasibility with respect to robot reachability and tool operations throughout bending sequence. Furthermore , the system shall support bending operations that requires for different sides of the work piece .Opposite side bending introduces additional constraint on tool orientation and robot configuration , which cannot always be resolved with a fixed handling strategy and time consuming .The system program therefore capable of adapting this strategy , including workpiece orientation and grip configuration, to enable such operation while maintaining feasibility

To structure the functional requirements, they are grouped into categories.

Operator Interaction Requirements: The system shall allow limited operator interaction for configuration of robot and process selection while minimizing the manual intervention during the execution. Before execution, the operator shall be able to specify the required process output, such side for bending or cad model for bending. During execution, the robot operation shall provide clear feedback or warning message when the given output conditions are unsafe for the process. The role of operator shall be restricted to configuration, while the program generation logic shall be handled automatically by the system.

Data Handling Requirements: The system should automatically use the operator input data and process the program that need to processed for

the required output in a consistent and reliable manner .This includes Handling geometries , grip position calculation, tracked poses , configuration parameters and intermediate state information generated during the time of execution. Data shall be used consistently across different stage of the program generation process to ensure that decisions regarding the handling and orientation and regripping are based on the current system state.

Motion Execution Requirements: The system shall generate feasible robot waypoints for all handling and bending related operations. This includes generation of approach waypoints, placement motions and the execution of orientation changes of the work piece and tool. Trajectory plans should be calculated prior to execution to prevent unreachable target poses. In addition, the system shall determine and apply appropriate grip positions on the workpiece to support handling and picking from different bending configurations. For opposite side bending operations, the system shall identify the grip position and waypoints such that required tool alignment can be achieved without violating the kinematical limits. Grip selection shall be treated as an integral part of the program generation process rather than manual integrated adjustments.

Error Handling and Regripping Requirements: The system shall be capable of detecting infeasible target poses or unsafe execution conditions before execution. When such conditions are detected, the system shall initiate a warning message to the user, trigger appropriate recovery actions instead of continuing execution. Recovery actions may include regripping or repositioning the workpiece to restore reachability. Regripping operation shall be supported as functional capability of the system .The system shall be able to integrate regripping sequence into generated robot program when direct trajectories to the target are unreachable or unsafe .If a critical error cannot be resolved through recovery actions , the system shall terminate execution in controlled regripping or repositioning manner to prevent unsafe robot behavior.

Table 3.1: Functional Requirements for Automatic Robot Program Generation

ID	Functional Requirement (SMART)	Acceptance Criteria	Verification Method
FR-01	The system shall detect unreachable target poses before robot motion execution	Robot does not execute motion to unreachable poses and provides an error message	Simulation Based
FR-02	The system shall allow the operator-side selection prior to program Execution	Selected bend side is applied correctly to the generated robot program	Simulation Based
FR-03	The system shall execute a regripping sequence when a target pose is unreachable within the current bend side	Regripping is performed successfully and execution continues without interruption	Simulation Based
FR-04	The system shall handle workpiece orientation changes during program execution	orientational changes are applied correctly without interrupting the kinematic limits	Simulation Based
FR-05	The system shall support opposite side bending operations when required	correctly handles opposite side bending operations	Simulation Based
FR-06	The system shall determine and apply suitable grip positions for each workpiece state	Grip positions are determined and applied correctly for each workpiece state	Simulation Based
FR-07	The system shall terminate execution when an unsafe operation is detected	Robots terminate execution and display an error message	Simulation Based

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